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A TARDY ENDING

IT WASN'T easy playing cricket. Nor was it easy leaving it.

I still remember the exact moment when it became clear that I was done.

We were in Adelaide, during the 2015 World Cup quarter-final against world champs Australia. Our scoreline wasn't reading too well. At 124 for 5, Umar Akmal had just been caught at mid-wicket attempting a lazy shot. Misbah-ul-Haq had been dismissed before him, caught at the same spot, by the same fielder. It seemed like almost everybody in the team was falling to outfield catching throughout the tournament. We weren't learning from our mistakes, collectively.

I walked out. My last seven innings against the Aussies, starting from 2010, had been 1, 2, 0, 7, 5, 2 and 6. Something bigger was needed.

I would try, but not really make a difference. With 24 runs off 15 balls, I would fire, then misfire, then miscue. Aaron Finch would catch me, near the boundary, off Josh Hazlewood.

My last shot in ODI cricket would be a pull. Maybe because I hadn't pushed myself enough. It wasn't a very glorious exit, not after 398 ODIs.

We would go on to fight with the ball. Wahab Riaz would bowl one of the most memorable spells in modern cricket, almost taking Shane Watson's head off a few times. After he would tire out, Australia would take over and then grab the World Cup too.

In Tests, I would be in and out of love, wrapping things up by 2006 and then making a begrudged start-and-stop in 2010. Tests weren't even for me. But if the stats are to be believed, I was made for Tests. The T20s – I would continue to play them till the World T20 in 2016, and then further on, the PSL and other leagues would be more my type of cricket; but that would be more entertainment than proper cricket, really. By 2017–18, I would even graduate to T10s. Hell, I'm going to be playing T5s at 60, if I ever get there.

But ODIs were and remain my first love. I debuted in an ODI. I would essentially end my career in one. My 37-ball century against Sri Lanka was a record that stood for 17 years till Corey